whispered that he would not even submit a proposal to the young Padshah before first ensuring the noblemen approved of it. If this made of Munim Khan a popular wakil, it resulted in the imperial coffers running dry, for many dues to the state remained uncollected, and a growing number of noblemen quietly siphoned booty away for themselves. Things became so dire that on one occasion, when Akbar applied to Maham Anaga for a sum of money, she had to give him the seventeen rupees from her own purse as the state coffers were empty.

Akbar now reacted to this situation, transferring Munim Khan's jagir from Hisar Firoza* to Alwar. Though he would eventually transfer it back to Munim Khan, it was a sharp reminder that Akbar was Padshah and was now determined to personally administer the strategically important fort of Hisar, having finally understood the need to both curb the power of his nobles and improve the state's finances.

While Maham Anaga was involved in the administration of the empire, she also began work on the first great building project of the Mughals in Delhi, the Khair-ul-Manazil mosque and madrasa. Built right across from the Deenpanah Fort of Humayun, and next to Sher Shah Sur's great gate, the Lal Darwaaza, the Khair-ul-Manazil mosque was built to proclaim Maham Anaga's crackling ambitions. In building a grand mosque and madrasa, Maham Anaga claimed for herself an ancient role that Timurid women were required to perform—visible piety. It was, at that time, one of the finest mosques in Delhi and the madrasa was a rare example of early Mughal female patronage of an educational institution. This structure was not built as a tribute to a son, a father, or a husband. The inscription at the entrance proudly proclaimed the name of the benefactress, 'Maham Beg, the Protector of Chastity, erected this building for the virtuous'. This monument, largely forgotten today, is a reminder of the influence 500 years ago of a non-royal woman, the only woman who never left Akbar's side from the moment she became his milk mother, the resilient nature of this ancient bond, and the endurance of the Padshah's love and respect for Maham Anaga.

There was another building that was begun at around the same time, much more vaulting in its ambitions and explosive in the cascading effect it would have on Mughal architecture. And yet, given the importance of this monument, it is surprising that so much of it remains shrouded in mystery, especially the exact date of its construction and its patron. When Humayun